

See also

Find out about evergreen trees, such as the giant sequoia (54–55) and coconut palm (56–57).

The upper parts of the tree are now buzzing with summer insects.

Male oak flowers, which produce pollen, hang in long tassels called catkins. Female flowers, which are harder to spot, grow in small clusters.

The female flower is fertilized by windblown pollen and forms an acorn, which is held in a protective woody cup.

Spring

While resting through winter, the oak has been saving its energy for spring. As the days grow warmer and longer, new green leaves grow from buds on the branches, and the tree flowers. Oaks have both male and female flowers.

Summer

During the long, hot days, leaves use sunlight to make food for the tree. This process is photosynthesis. The acorns formed by the flowers ripen in late summer. Acorns are a type of hard-shelled fruit called nuts.

Spreading seeds

Most acorns are eaten before they can germinate. However, animals that eat acorns help oaks spread to new places, too. Squirrels bury acorns to store them for winter, but they sometimes forget where they left them. Birds may accidentally drop acorns in midflight. The forgotten acorns may then grow into new trees, away from the parent oak.